



DEMETRIUS FREEMAN/THE WASHINGTON POST

RFK Jr. faces blistering questions on vaccines, abortion from Democrats

This article is by Dan Diamond, Rachel Roubein, Lauren Weber, Lena H. Sun and Fenit Nirappil

Robert F. Kennedy Jr. faced a divided panel of senators Wednesday, with Democrats deeply critical of the vaccine skeptic's bid to serve as America's top health official, and Republicans insisting that the former liberal was the right choice to lead a nearly \$2 trillion agency that helps shape everyday life.

Democrats blistered Kennedy with questions that he struggled to answer, such as whether he stood by his most controversial claims appearing on podcasts and in books and interviews, and how he would oversee the Department of Health and Human Services if confirmed as its secretary. They pushed him to defend his shifting stance on abortion and whether he would simply rubber-stamp President Donald Trump's agenda, or if he would use his perch to continue raising doubts about vaccines — often quoting Kennedy's own words back at him.

"Unlike other jobs that we're confirming around this place, this

is a job where it is life and death," said Sen. Michael Bennet (D-Colorado), after asking Kennedy whether he had said the coronavirus pandemic may have been a genetically engineered bioweapon. "It's too important for the games that you're playing, Mr. Kennedy."

Republicans countered that Kennedy, a former environmental lawyer who led an anti-vaccine organization, had reassured them of his qualifications and tried to keep the focus on America's high rate of chronic disease, which Kennedy has vowed to bring down. Several praised him as a would-be reformer, insisting that Kennedy was asking difficult questions about the nature of health-care industry conflicts — and suffering a political beating in response.

"I think I know the personal and political price you paid for this decision," said Sen. Ron Johnson (R-Wisconsin), a staunch supporter of Kennedy.

Sen. Roger Marshall (R-Kansas), a physician, invoked his faith when praising Kennedy.

SEE KENNEDY ON A6



JABIN BOTSFORD/THE WASHINGTON POST

FROM TOP: Robert F. Kennedy Jr. appears at a confirmation hearing Wednesday on Capitol Hill for leadership of the Department of Health and Human Services. President Donald Trump walks to the East Room on Wednesday to sign into law the Laken Riley Act, the first such signing of his second term.

What happened on Wednesday

The Senate confirmed Lee Zeldin, a former Republican congressman from New York, as the administrator of the Environmental Protection Agency. **A6**

The president signed three executive orders seeking to control how schools teach about race and gender, direct more tax dollars to private schools, and deport pro-Palestinian campus protesters. **A9**

Homeland Security Secretary Kristi L. Noem revoked the Biden administration's 18-month extension of temporary protections from deportation for hundreds of thousands of Venezuelan immigrants. **A10**

White House office withdraws order that froze spending

REVERSAL FOLLOWS MASS CHAOS, BACKLASH

Memo had paused funding for key government grants

BY JEFF STEIN AND TONY ROMM

The White House budget office on Wednesday rescinded an order freezing federal grants after the administration's move to halt spending earlier this week provoked a backlash.

In the memo distributed to federal agencies, Matthew J. Vaeth, acting director of the White House Office of Management and Budget, states that OMB memorandum M-25-13 "is rescinded." That order, issued Monday, instructed federal agencies to "temporarily pause all

activities related to obligations or disbursement of all federal financial assistance."

The White House order freezing federal grants caused mass chaos and confusion across Washington, appearing to imperil government programs that fund schools, provide housing and ensure that low-income Americans have access to health care. States reported problems accessing money under Medicaid, and early Wednesday, some public housing authorities reported still being locked out of their funding portal, though access cleared up later.

SEE TRUMP ON A7

Anti-HIV efforts: Pause on foreign aid throws program into crisis. **A14**

Buyout: Resign? Fight? Federal workers consider Trump's offer. **B1**

Buyout proposal highlights Musk's broad influence

BY EMILY DAVIES, JEFF STEIN AND FAIZ SIDDIQUI

Billionaire Elon Musk's influence over a traditionally nonpartisan agency that oversees the federal workforce culminated in the government's stunning proposal Tuesday offering employees an inducement to resign, according to four people familiar with the situation who spoke on the condition of anonymity to describe internal talks.

The proposal, emailed late in the day to many of the nation's 2.3 million federal workers, blindsided some advisers to President Donald Trump, including officials in the budget office and agencies that typically would be consulted in advance of such monumental changes to personnel and spending policies, the people said.

Since Trump took office, Musk has moved quickly to exert control over the Office of Personnel Management, the small inde-

SEE MUSK ON A9

Trump skirts and stretches laws on the civil service

BY LISA REIN

With a blizzard of executive orders, President Donald Trump has jump-started an extraordinary plan to transform the federal government into a leaner operation packed with his loyalists.

The fine print of those directives reveals how shrewdly the new administration is maneuvering — and sometimes outright ignoring — the arcane laws, rules and regulations that have long protected the civil service of 2.3 million from a political takeover.

Trump has skirted Biden-era rules by essentially declaring them unlawful, used probationary periods to place masses of civil servants in limbo and issued a memo lifting restrictions on hiring temporary political appointees to replace thousands of career employees. The White House has even declared that Trump can overrule a post-Watergate law to summarily fire senior executives and career prosecutors, citing a

SEE CIVIL SERVICE ON A8

Trump orders 30,000-bed Guantánamo deportee camp

BY NICK MIROFF AND DAN LAMOTHE

President Donald Trump on Wednesday ordered the construction of a detention camp with 30,000 beds at the Guantánamo Bay Naval Base in Cuba, outlining plans for a site outside U.S. territory where immigrants caught in his expanding deportation campaign could be sent.

Speaking at the White House before signing the Laken Riley Act, a bill expected to expand the number of immigrants held in U.S. custody for minor crimes, Trump said the massive site in Guantánamo would "detain the worst criminal illegal aliens threatening the American people" and be "a tough place to get out of."

"Some of them are so bad, we

don't even trust other countries to hold them, and we don't want them coming back, so we're going to send them out to Guantánamo," Trump said. "This will double our capacity immediately."

U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement has detention capacity for about 40,000 immigrants facing deportation. The largest facilities in its network have roughly 2,000 beds, so the Guantánamo military site Trump described would dwarf any location ICE oversees within the United States.

Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth, during an interview on Fox News, said the base was "a perfect place" to hold deportees.

"Beyond the facilities used to house terrorists that many are familiar with," Hegseth said, the

SEE GUANTANAMO ON A7



Prison for Menendez

The former senator is sentenced to 11 years for corruption scheme. **A2**



KEVIN FRAYER/GETTY IMAGES

A roaring start to Lunar New Year

A traditional lion dance Wednesday at Dongyue Temple in Beijing is part of festivities marking the beginning of the Year of the Snake. The Lunar New Year holiday, which opens during the second new moon after the winter solstice, is celebrated by more than 1 billion people, including in China and much of the rest of Asia, as well as among the global Asian diaspora.

Bodies pulled from Potomac after collision of aircraft

BY TEO ARMUS, KATIE SHEPHERD, DAN LAMOTHE AND EMILY DAVIES

An American Airlines flight from Wichita with at least 60 passengers onboard collided with a military helicopter near Reagan National Airport shortly before 9 p.m. Wednesday evening.

Police pulled multiple bodies from the Potomac River as part of a massive emergency response, according to two people familiar with the situation who spoke on the condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to discuss the incident.

The helicopter was an Army Black Hawk, two defense officials told The Washington Post. At least three U.S. soldiers were onboard at the time of the collision, a senior defense official said. No senior U.S. leaders were on the

SEE CRASH ON A2

IN THE NEWS

Rubbish idea? Miami-Dade County may build a huge trash incinerator, a plan some scientists see as a least-bad option. Problem is, nobody wants it. **A11**

No rate change The Fed began its wait-and-see stance amid a cloudy economic outlook and uncertainty over Trump's policies. **A16**

THE NATION Researchers have linked wildfire smoke exposure to an increased risk of dementia. **A2**
The share of U.S. workers in unions fell in 2024, reaching its lowest level on record. **A4**

THE WORLD Pakistan is seeing a surge in polio cases as militant groups target vaccination teams. **A12**
At least 30 people were killed in a stampede at a huge Hindu festival in India. **A13**

THE ECONOMY Police logs show that after the killing of UnitedHealthcare's CEO, police activity picked up at executives' homes. **A15**
Bankrupt Spirit Airlines quickly rejected a new offer from Frontier Airlines to merge and create one large low-cost carrier. **A16**

THE REGION Despite some gains, Washington-area students' performance is still lagging after covid, data shows. **B1**
The trial of an alleged neo-Nazi who has been charged with trying to destroy power stations in Maryland got underway. **B1**

STYLE Chappell Roan is up for four of the top Grammys. If she doesn't win, it doesn't necessarily mean she lost. **C1**

LOCAL LIVING Despite much scorn for neutral colors, they have remained hugely popular in interior design for a reason.

BUSINESS NEWS.....A15
COMICS.....C5
OBITUARIES.....B4
OPINION PAGES.....A17
TELEVISION.....C4
WORLD NEWS.....A12

CONTENT © 2025
The Washington Post
Year 148, No. 54112

